

Mountain Heritage Trust

2017 Annual Report



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Summary

2017 has been another busy year for the Mountain Heritage Trust with office relocation, a major repackaging project, a new exhibition, a successful Heritage Lottery Fund bid, continued partner working, attendance at events, and recruitment of new Trustees and staff, along with significant acquisitions and numerous enquiries.

From January-March the Trust relocated its office and collections from Station House in Penrith to the Blencathra Field Centre. Following this a major repackaging project began with the support of several volunteers.

April saw the Trust partnering with the National Trust and Arc'teryx in Langdale for an evening event and a publicly accessible stand for a full weekend.

In May we got the news that our Heritage Lottery Fund bid, for a project linking Chris Bonington to the Cumbrian landscape, had been successful. This led to work beginning on the three major areas of the project: oral history gathering, exhibition planning, and the recruitment of a member of staff to deliver a programme of engagement activities.

The summer saw development of the Trust's new exhibition British Women Climb – which launched in September and featured loans from a range of organisations including the Alpine Club, Fell and Rock Climbing Club, Pinnacle Club, the British Mountaineering Council, Rohan and Cumbria Archives; as well as from individuals including world bouldering champion Shauna Coxsey.

Throughout the year the Trust has also worked to develop its collections taking in 44 new collections and individual objects. We have worked to promote access to the collections in our care by answering 85 enquiries, supporting researchers and independent projects linked to mountain heritage, and participating in the running of family events at Keswick Museum. We have also been seen out and about promoting the Trust's work at a range of events – from the British Mountaineering Council AGM to Kendal Mountain Festival.

Enquiries and Acquisitions

Enquiries

We had 85 enquiries in 2017, an increase on last year. These range from requests for information and to carry out research, to offers of archive/library material, and requests for images for use in a variety of media.

Acquisitions

We have had a wonderful range of acquisitions in 2017 – a total of 44 individual donations ranging from a single book to over 100 boxes.

Significant donations include:

- Mike Westmacott's 1953 Everest expedition sleeping bag
- Dick Renshaw's 1975 Dunagiri jacket
- the Johnnie Lees Collection
- the Tom Price Collection
- boots believed to have been used by Don Whillans on Annapurna in 1970
- overshoes used by John Scott on the 1976 Army Everest expedition
- Frank Grant's research papers relating to WP Haskett Smith
- a number of pieces of kit and clothing used by Ron Kenyon
- the George Band Collection
- the Joe Tasker and Pete Boardman slide collections
- numerous donations of kit, books and magazines



2017/24: Bolting kit used by Ron Kenyon in 1972 on the direct star to Rat Salad route in the Eden Valley.

Projects

Archive and office relocation to Blencathra FSC

A major project which involved:

- Supervision of the building works at Blencathra FSC to make the former boathouse suitable for heritage collection storage
- Moving the office and library from Station House to Blencathra FSC
- Moving the archive from Station House to Blencathra FSC
- Developing new processes for operating at Blencathra FSC
- Publicising the relocation
- Launching the Trust at its new location
- Ensuring compliance with FSC health and safety processes, e.g. PAT testing of equipment
- Volunteer Lindsay Cowen has worked hard to get the reference library, along with some new additions, onto the shelves and listed
- Tim Foster and the FSC have been very supportive throughout this process and continue to be excellent landlords
- The move attracted significant regional publicity with articles in Cumbria Life, local newspapers, Radio Cumbria, and local BBC news, as well as specialist publications including: Mountain Rescue magazine, Trail and promotion online by the BMC.
- The project was funded through a legacy received via the BMC (building work) and a grant from The Mercers' Company (shelving, reboxing and dehumidifier)



Above: building work in progress, Autumn 2016



Right: The new store with shelf fitting in progress

Reboxing project

As part of the £16,757 award from the Mercers' Company the Trust purchased 400 archival standard boxes to re-house collections which were stored in various containers unsuitable for long term preservation. Three volunteers were recruited to assist with this project.

One of the key areas for reboxing was the Trust's magazine and journal collections (nb. No one went through the list of titles to give me guidance on which were significant so I have made appraisal decisions based on the collections development policy).

So far, the volunteers have reboxed, sorted, numbered, and listed (at issue level only at this point) 16 titles; we have focused on tackling the titles with large numbers of issues first.

Most other titles have been reboxed and had an accession number added but there are still more than 90 titles sort and list.

We have run out of boxes (due to substantial magazine acquisition after the bid was submitted) so a request has been made to the Mercers' Company to use some of the contingency funds to purchase additional boxes.

Johnnie Lees digitisation

Following the donation of £3000 towards preserving and making accessible this collection the following action has been taken:

- £2000 was been spent employing Tony Riley to digitise the tightly rolled negative films which form the bulk of the collection (1,112 images). These were previously completely inaccessible so we now have catalogue quality (400dpi) scans available so the collection can be catalogued.
- Guidelines and a template for volunteers have been drawn up to work on cataloguing the images.

Joe Tasker Heritage Lottery Fund project

While the exhibition and cataloguing for this project were completed in 2016, there was still substantial work required to successfully wrap up the project. Reporting was completed in June 2017.

The exhibition element of the project will be extended with a display at Preston Park Museum in Stockton-on-Tees from March-May 2018.

Man and Mountain Heritage Lottery Fund project

In May 2017 the Trust was awarded a grant of up to £49,400 by the Heritage Lottery Fund for the project Man and Mountain: Chris Bonington, Cumbria and Beyond. The project will have three major elements which have all progressed in 2017:

Oral History

- Volunteers have been recruited and training carried out by an Oral History Society approved practitioner
- Recording equipment has been purchased
- A list of subjects for interview and potential topics of conversation has been drawn up
- Oral history processes have been developed, written and circulated to volunteers

Exhibition

- Keswick Museum will host an exhibition using Chris Bonington's life as the centrepiece to explore changes in mountaineering in the 20th century and links between Cumbria and the wider mountaineering world.
- Julie Summers has been appointed guest curator and has undertaken substantial research using Chris' archive at the Trust.
- Tenders were invited from a number of designers and four quotes were received. RFA Design were appointed as the exhibition designer in November 2017.

Learning and Engagement Programme

A programme of learning and engagement events and resources will be created to run alongside the exhibition. These will be developed and piloted by a part-time, one year post for a Learning and Engagement Officer. Recruitment to this role was carried out in December 2017.

GDPR

2018 will see the introduction of a new Data Protection law in the UK based on the EU General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). To ensure compliance with the new regulation a review of data protection policies and practices is being undertaken by Kelda Roe with support from Will Lownsbrough. Kelda has attended training and also communicated with Kate Anwyl at the BMC regarding sharing of training, processes and approaches. So far an audit of electronic records has been undertaken at the Trust, with areas for further work identified.

A full plan should be developed in early 2018 as the legislation comes into force in May 2018.

Events

Date	Event
21 February 2017, 11 April 2017, 18 April 2017	Keswick Museum family activities – Prepare to Climb family activity aimed at primary school aged children (in partnership with the museum and George Fisher)
22 April 2017	BMC Annual General Meeting
27 April 2017	Workshop for University of Durham English Literature undergraduate students
28-30 April 2017	Arc'teryx Big Mountain Weekend
9-11 June 2017	Keswick Mountain Festival
9-22 September 2017	Display at Blencathra Centre as part of C-Art open studios event
17-19 November 2017	Kendal Mountain Festival
24 November 2017	West Yorkshire Scouts fundraiser with Nigel Vardy
29 December 2017	An evening of conversation with Terry Abraham, led by MHT Patron John Innerdale, at National Trust Sticklebarn.

Partnership Work

BMC

As a British Mountaineering Council Trust which is also part funded by the BMC, the Mountain Heritage Trust seeks to work closely with the BMC. This has proved challenging in 2017 because BMC staff have been heavily involved with managing responses to a vote of no confidence and the subsequent organisational review. However, the Trust has successfully worked with the BMC on a number of events and projects this year including:

- Attending the BMC AGM in April 2017
- Keswick Mountain Festival
- Kendal Mountain Festival
- Digital media (cross promotion of events and projects)

Additionally the Trust has contributed to the BMC organisational review. A focus group was attended by Kelda Roe and John Porter with opinions from other Trustees sought in advance.

Keswick Museum

The Mountain Heritage Trust has an ongoing relationship with Keswick Museum and has hosted four temporary exhibitions since the museum's refurbishment in 2013. Collaboration has continued in 2017:

- In late 2016/early 2017 the Trust acted as intermediary to enable the loan of the Abraham Brothers' Instanto camera for Henry Iddon's exhibition which ran from January-May 2017. The Trust also loaned books to the museum for the exhibition.
- In the February half-term holiday and the spring school holidays, the Collections Manager worked with the museum and George Fisher on a collaborative family activity at the museum entitled Prepare to Climb. This was linked to the Abraham Brothers' exhibition and offered families the chance to explore materials used in climbing and hill-walking clothing in the past and the present day.
- In September 2017 the Trust installed a new temporary exhibition in the museum. British Women Climb explores the history of British women's climbing and mountaineering. Graphics were designed by Chris Sherwin of CSDesigns and the exhibition will run until September 2018.
- Development of the British Women Climb exhibition has been a success for the Trust's relationship with the museum – the Trust's Collections Manager consulted with the museum's Curator to ensure that the museum's aims were met for engagement.
- Development of the British Women Climb exhibition has also been a positive process for the Trust's relationships with other organisations and includes loans and support from the BMC, clubs (Alpine Club and Pinnacle Club), businesses (Rohan), and individuals (Gwen Moffat, Angela Soper, Tessa Lyons and Shauna Coxsey).

Allan Bank – National Trust

This year we have had two work experience students volunteering at Allan Bank, both of whom chose to spend some of their time focusing on the Chorley Hopkinson Mountaineering Library.

The 2016's library intern's project has also been completed and the display in the library room has been reinvented with photographs linking to books and themes in the library.

Sticklebarn – National Trust

On the 28th April 2017 the National Trust and Mountain Heritage Trust collaborated for an evening of heritage, film and food at Sticklebarn in Langdale. Mountain Heritage Trust Patron John Innerdale led an entertaining 'in conversation' with climber and Langdale resident Dave Birkett; this was followed by short films from the Pathé archive and a hearty dinner.

The event was a successful pilot and it is planned to repeat the format with different speakers in winter 2017/2018.

University of Cumbria

The Mountain Heritage Trust continues to maintain its stores at the University of Cumbria's Ambleside campus and has had several communications regarding potential future collaboration. It is hoped that the relationship will grow and develop in 2018 and beyond.

Lancaster University

The Trust maintains communication with Lancaster University. In 2017 we maintained our place on their list of contacts for history work experience placements but decided not to take placements this year due to the large number of other commitments.

The Trust also offered a letter of support and the potential for collaboration to Dr Joanna Taylor. Dr Taylor submitted a bid to the British Academy linking literature and women's climbing. The bid was not successful but there is still an appetite for future collaboration.

Southport Young Roots

In the first half of 2017 the Trust offered support to Southport. Unfortunately the bid was unsuccessful but it suggests that there is an appetite among younger audiences for both learning about the heritage of and participating in outdoor activities.

Scaling the Heights

Artists Stephen and Margaret Livingstone are working in partnership with Durham University on a project linking mountain heritage, mountaineering libraries and childhood nostalgia. They are researching some of the most iconic climbs in mountaineering history and recreating them in miniature on significant mountaineering libraries. The recreations are being photographed and will be displayed with interpretation panels at Durham Oriental Museum in late 2018.

Recruitment

Trustees

In April an advert was placed in various online locations calling for new Trustees to support the Trust – specifically in marketing, fundraising and events management. Following shortlisting and interview, we welcomed Carole Osborne (events), Will Lownsborough (marketing) and Liz Sutton (fundraising). Tomo Thompson joined us as an Ambassador and we welcome his support in developing links with mountain heritage in the Armed Forces.

In December, Dr Charlie Clarke resigned as a Trustee due to other commitments. Charlie became a Trustee in 2015 and, in addition to his knowledge of mountain heritage and experience as an expedition doctor, made a significant impact on the Trust through the organisation of a major fundraiser in London. The Trust thanks Charlie for his hard work and support of mountain heritage.

Administrator and Social Media Coordinator

In July Nicole Reeve left her role as part-time Administrator and Social Media Coordinator for the Trust to relocate to Canada. In August we recruited to this vacancy and welcomed Jonny Dry to the team.

Learning and Engagement Officer

In December 2017 we recruited to the role of Learning and Engagement Officer for the Man and Mountain project. A further announcement will be made in January 2018.